

THE UNIVERSAL HOUSE OF JUSTICE

1999-08-05

1 dear bahá'í friends,

2 1999 . . . and has asked us to respond as follows.306.1

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308 1996–2000 • The four Year Plan

309 685The house of justice is pleased to note that you are planning to give

310 greater attention to the advancement of women in both the internal func-

311 tioning of your bahá'í community and in your external affairs activities.

The establishment of an office for the Advancement of women has the

312 potential to provide a powerful reinforcement to the efforts of the believers

313 in this important aspect of bahá'í endeavor. in response to your question

314 about the appointment of a member of your National Spiritual Assembly as the
director of the office, the house of justice feels that this matter should

315 be left to your discretion; however, it advises you to consider carefully the possibility
that the appointment of a member, or of a close family relative

of a member, could well be misunderstood by your bahá'í community and

316 thus create a negative impression. you are encouraged to seek the views of

317 the counselors on this point, and indeed on the other aspects of the new

318 initiative you are now planning.

319 you have in several places referred to your distress at the attitudes and

conduct of some male members of the bahá'í community concerning the

320 advancement of women, in their regarding it as an issue which concerns only
women, or reacting to it through immoderate language or inappropri-

321 ate humor. in assisting them to acquire an understanding that they have a

322 vital role to play in the implementation of this principle of the faith, you

323 have many possible approaches from which to select. for example, their
324 participation in a careful study of the compilation on women would serve to bring to
their attention those passages in the document which refer clearly to the efforts which are
required of men. A contemplation of the peerless ex-
325 ample of the life of 'Abdu'l-b ahá should include a study of his actions and
326 statements to advance the status and development of women. The messages
327 of the house of justice, calling upon all elements of the bahá'í community
328 for a greater commitment to the advancement of women, must also be given
329 due weight in considering the responsibility of men in this regard.

your recommendation that the compilation on women be revised is

330 noted, and will be considered in due course, most especially as the amount
331 of material to be included in it expands with elucidations of the house of
332 justice in response to the needs of the developing bahá'í community. The
333 experience you mention, that of individuals focusing on only one passage from the
present document and using it as a vehicle in attempting to press
334 their views on an individual who has a different understanding, is not solved
335 simply by a reordering of the passages; rather it points to a need for deeper study and
more careful reading, by which is obtained a comprehensive un-307 .2

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308 m e S a g e S f r o m T h e u n i v e r S a l h o u S e o f j u S T i c e

309 686derstanding of this complex subject such that all passages are seen to be ele-
310 ments of a harmonious whole. in striving to attain this state, account must
311 also be taken of the statements of the house of justice in the introduction
312 to The Kitáb-i-Aqdas concerning the progressive clarification and progres-
313 sive application of the laws of the faith through the instrumentality of the
314 covenant.

315 you refer to the view which exists in some quarters of your community,
316 based apparently on a passage written on behalf of the guardian to two
317 believers in response to a particular situation, that it is not appropriate to create
bahá'í agencies such as an office for the Advancement of women or
318 to hold meetings to which only women are invited. Such a view ignores the clear
advice and encouragement set out in several messages of the house

319 of justice concerning the implementation of the principle of equality of
 320 the sexes, or the actions it has taken in setting up an office for the Ad-
 321 vancement of women in the united Nations office in New york. Attention
should also be drawn to the letter of 25 may 1975 from the house of
 322 justice to all National Spiritual Assemblies, in which reference is made to
 323 eighty National Spiritual Assemblies being called upon specifically to orga-nize
 bahá'í activities for women.
 324 307-1 passages in the compilation on women
 325 include the call by 'Abdu'l-b ahá for "women's assemblages," his mention
 326 of some of the subjects which should be discussed at such gatherings, and his
 warning against an approach which would lead to greater disharmony
 327 and argumentation between men and women. Thus those men who are apprehensive
 about meetings of women can be reassured that these bahá'í
 328 gatherings would not degenerate into the contentiousness and antagonism toward
 males which appears in some such meetings organized by radical or extremist elements in
 the wider society.

in the conduct of your activities for the advancement of women, you

329 should take great care to avoid unquestioning acceptance of approaches and themes
 which influence the efforts toward that end in the world around you. Statistics on the
 participation of women on bahá'í institutions are compiled
 330 from time to time by bahá'í agencies, including the bahá'í international

community's united Nations office for the Advancement of women, and

331 have been published on occasion in the annual Bahá'í World year book.
 332 however, caution should be observed in their interpretation, because of
 333 307-1. muhj, no. 162.307 .5
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 308 1996–2000 • T h e f o u r Y e a r P l a n
 309 687the small size of the bahá'í communities in most countries, and the differ-
 310 ences in the traditional attitudes toward the participation of women in the
 311 various cultures represented in the worldwide community. it would also
 312 be improper to use these results in an attempt to ensure that the composi-
 313 tion of institutions is evenly balanced between the sexes, since believers are enjoined
 to select those best qualified to serve, irrespective of their sex.

The faith does not seek to promote the advancement of women through

314 an artificial endeavor to achieve parity, but rather through a fundamen-
315 tal transformation of values and understanding coupled with the creation of
opportunities and encouragement for the development of talents and
316 capabilities.

likewise, bahá'í institutions are admonished in the teachings to con-

317 sider the welfare and sentiments of all elements of their community in their
318 decision-making, and to create opportunities for all to participate in consul-
319 tation at gatherings such as the Nineteen day feast.

The sharing of bahá'í material developed in one country with others

320 can be accomplished in a variety of ways, including use of the bahá'í inter-
national community's office for the Advancement of women, as well as
321 advertising in your [national newsletter].

your comments on the convention on the elimination of all forms of

322 discrimination against women illustrate the point made earlier about the

need for care in determining the extent to which the bahá'í community

323 should identify with the initiatives of non-bahá'í bodies. A document such
324 as the convention should be studied to ascertain whether the provisions
325 are, in fact, wholly compatible with the bahá'í teachings. As you are aware,
326 the faith upholds the equality of the sexes but specifies a differentiation
327 of functions in some areas, such as educational priorities when resources are limited,
service in armed defense forces, membership of the univer-
328 sal house of justice, exemption from certain laws in the kitáb-i-Aqdas,
329 intestacy provisions, and so on, which could be perceived as effecting a
discrimination between men and women.

330 you are assured of the prayers of the house of justice in the holy Shrines

331 on your behalf, as you embark on a process which could well prove to be a powerful
means of promoting the interests of the cause of bahá'u'lláh in

332 . . . and beyond.

333 with loving bahá'í greetings,

for Department of the Secretariat 307 .7

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Message to the Indigenous Teaching Conference

in Sucre, Bolivia

[signed: The Universal House of Justice]